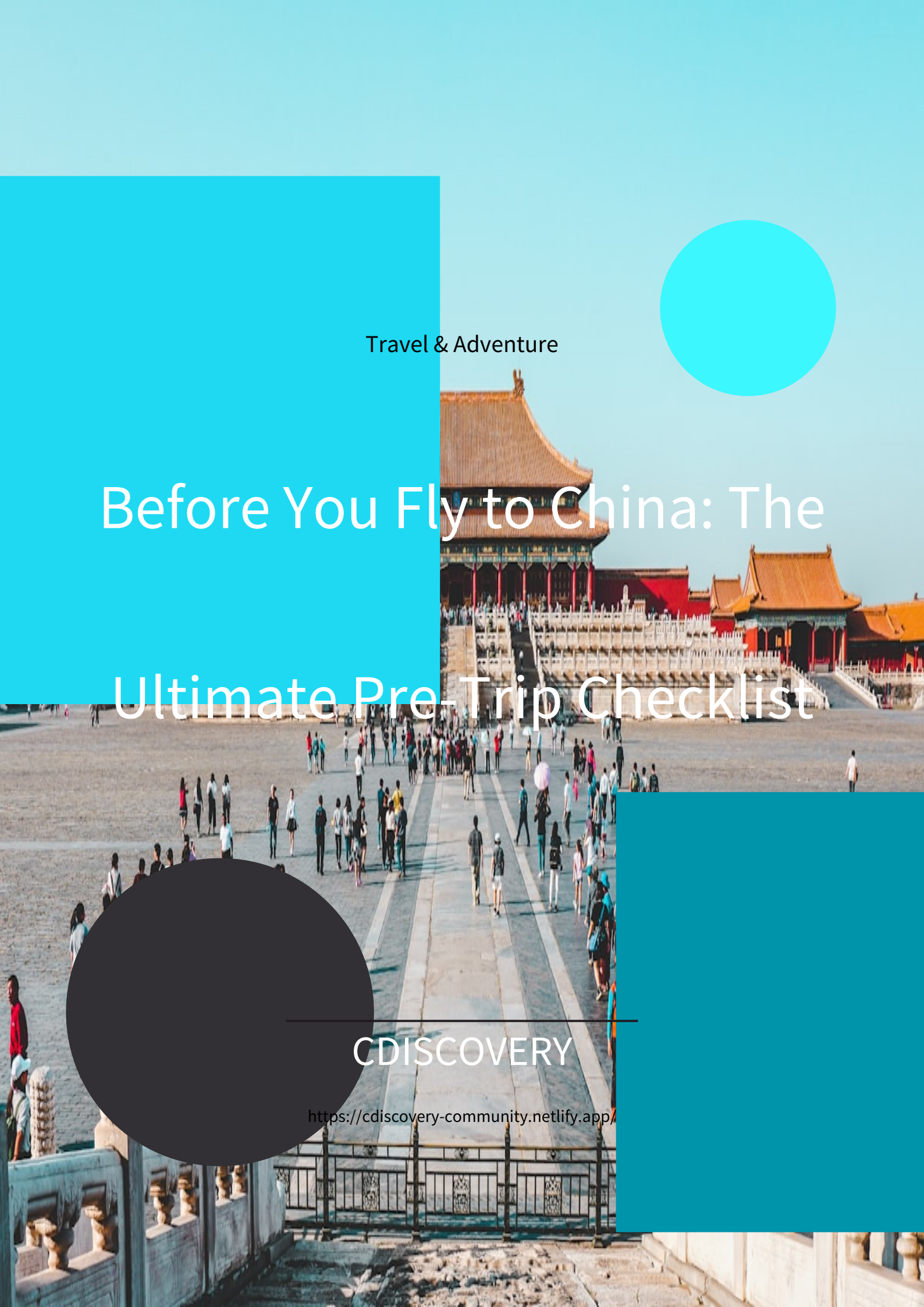




Travel & Adventure

Before You Fly to China: The Ultimate Pre-Trip Checklist

CDISCOVERY

<https://cdiscovery-community.netlify.app/>



Before You Fly to China: The Ultimate Pre-Trip

Checklist

I recently asked people what they were most worried about before traveling to China, and the answers were surprisingly consistent. Here are the most common concerns -- and practical solutions for each.

Top Concerns First-Time Visitors Have:

- * Payment:

- * How to use Alipay / WeChat Pay / international bank cards

- * Apps:

- * Chinese apps work differently than overseas versions

- * Language barrier:



* What to do when things go wrong

* Booking:

* How to book train tickets and attraction tickets

* Preparation:

* What to set up before landing

Before You Fly -- Essential Setup:

* Set up Alipay and WeChat Pay

* -- These are absolutely essential. Cash is rarely accepted in most places. Link your international credit card to both apps before you leave home.

* Add your international credit card

* to both Alipay and WeChat Pay if possible. Visa, Mastercard, and JCB are now supported.

* Download an offline translation app



* -- Google Translate doesn't work well in China. Use Apple Translate, Microsoft

Translator, or Pleco (best for Chinese).

* Save your hotel address in Chinese

* -- You'll need to show it to taxi drivers. Screenshot the Chinese address from your booking confirmation.

* Prepare a backup payment method

* -- Bring some cash (¥500-1000) just in case. ATMs at airports accept international cards.

* Check if your eSIM/roaming works in China

* -- Many international SIM cards don't work behind the Great Firewall. Get a China eSIM (Airalo, Holafly) or buy a local SIM at the airport.

* Know what doesn't work in China:

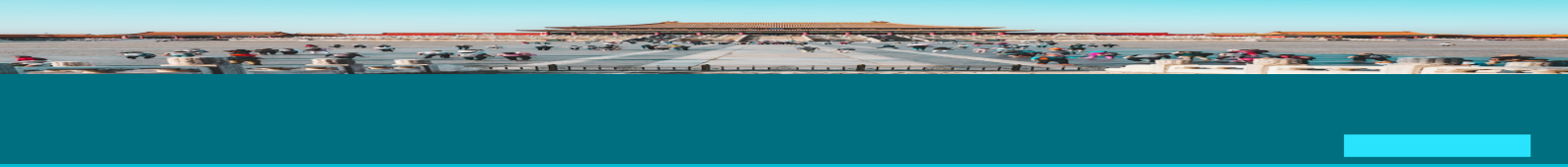
* Google, WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter/X, Gmail -- all blocked.

Download a VPN before arrival, or use Chinese alternatives (Baidu, WeChat, Douyin).



After You Land -- First Steps:

- * Test payments with a small purchase first
- * -- Buy a drink or snack to make sure Alipay/WeChat Pay works before you rely on it.
- * Set up DiDi (滴滴出行) through Alipay or WeChat
- * -- This is China's Uber. It's integrated into both apps, so no separate download needed.
- * Always carry your passport
- * -- Required for train travel, hotel check-in, and sometimes SIM card purchase. Keep a photo on your phone as backup.
- * Don't rely only on Google Maps
- * -- It's inaccurate in China. Use Amap (高德地图) or Baidu Maps (百度地图) instead. Apple Maps works okay.
- * Book popular attractions earlier than you think
- * -- The Forbidden City, Terracotta Army, and other top sites often sell out days in



advance. Book via the official WeChat mini-program or Trip.com.

* Train tickets:

* Book via 12306 app or Trip.com. Passport required for purchase AND boarding. Arrive

30-45 min early.

Pro Tips From Experienced Travelers:

* Carry a power bank -- you'll use your phone for everything (payments, maps,

translation)

* Carry tissues -- many public restrooms don't provide toilet paper

* Learn basic phrases: 你好 (nǐ hǎo = hello), 谢谢 (xièxie = thank you), 多少钱 (duōshao

qián = how much), 厕所在哪里 (cèsuǒ zài nǎlǐ = where's the bathroom)

* Tap water is NOT drinkable -- buy bottled water or boil it

* China uses one time zone (UTC+8) for the entire country -- this means sunrise in

western China can be as late as 10 AM

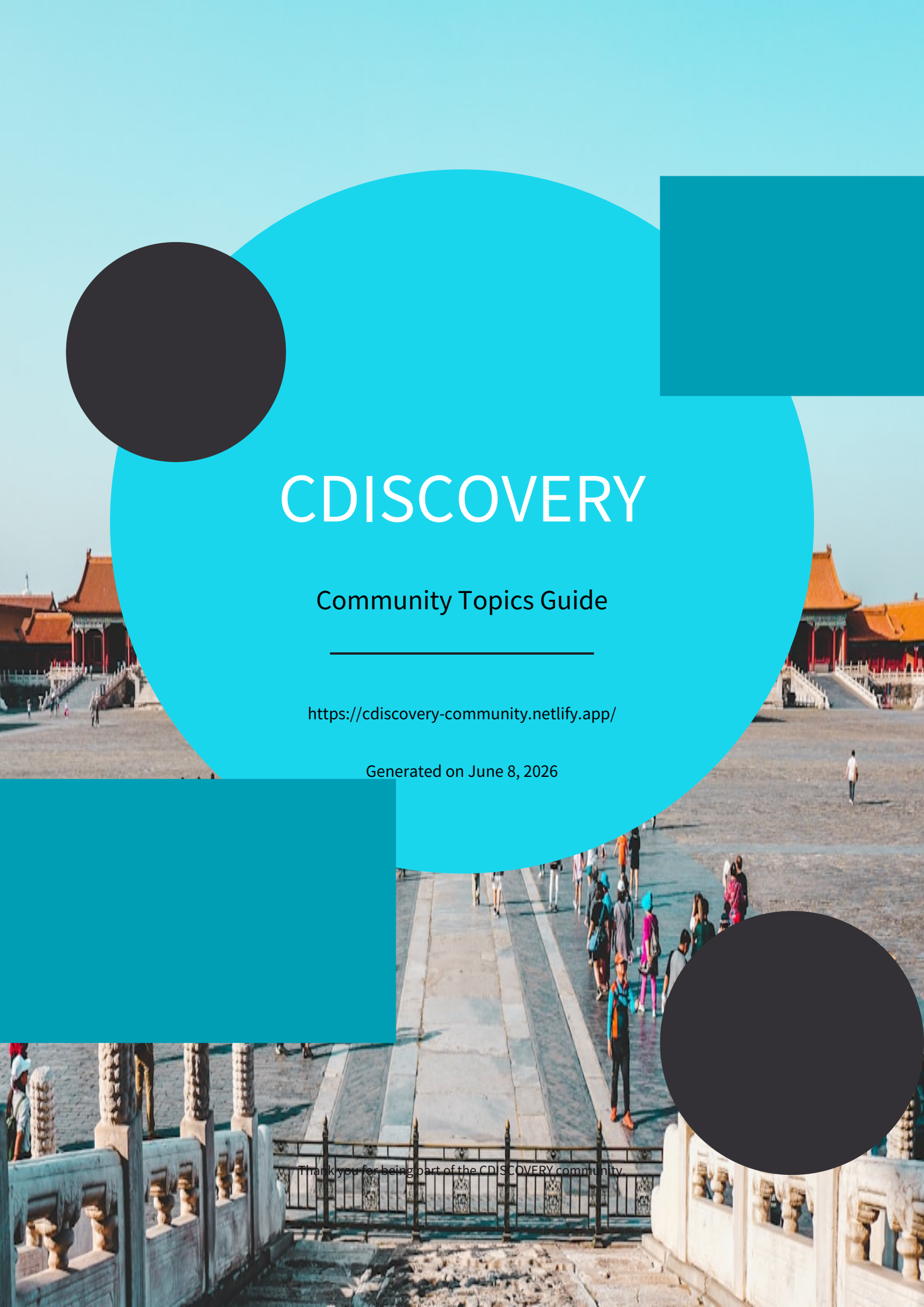


* Bring a universal adapter -- China uses Type A, C, and I outlets

China is one of the safest and most convenient countries to travel in -- once you have the right apps set up. The learning curve is steep for the first 24 hours, but after that, everything becomes incredibly smooth.

Sources: Sources: Community experiences • [China](https://www.chinahighlights.com)

Highlights • [Trip.com](https://www.trip.com)



CDISCOVERY

Community Topics Guide

<https://cdiscovery-community.netlify.app/>

Generated on June 8, 2026

Thank you for being part of the CDISCOVERY community